to the Indian battlefield, could create deadly chaos by moving with great speed to any point on the battlefield. Both sides were pushed beyond endurance in the merciless summer sun because of which ‘the very brain boiled in the cranium’. Disarray and confusion began overtaking the Mughal side. That was when Mihtar Khan, commanding the rear, beat his war drums and shouted out to the Mughal soldiers that the Padshah himself was coming so that ‘this shout of his was to a great extent the cause of the fugitives taking heart again and making a stand’. So galvanizing was the thought of the Padshah that Man Singh’s Rajput bodyguard rallied once more around their young leader and Badauni wonderingly noted that ‘a Hindu wields the sword of Islam’. Exhausted by the relentless sun, and suddenly demoralized, the rana’s men lost heart and the battle was won for the Mughals while Rana Pratap, ‘despite fighting very bravely and getting many wounds’, was persuaded by his men to leave the battlefield. ‘The Rana turned and fled,’ wrote Badauni rather more curtly, and ‘betook himself to the high mountains…and there sought to shut himself up as in a fortress.’

In the blinding sun the Mughals counted their dead, some 120 men, while another 300 were wounded. Of the Rana’s men, 380 lay dead on the ‘Field of Blood’, the Rati-Talai. The Mughal army encamped at Gogunda, having first barricaded the streets and dug a protective trench. No effort was made to pursue or capture the rana, and though the Mughal army was exhausted, it is generally believed that Man Singh was not keen to further humiliate or disgrace the rana. He even forbade the ravaging and looting of the rana’s territory, which would have been standard practice at the time. The Mughal army lacked for food and grain and was reduced to eating ‘the flesh of animals and the mango-fruit’, which soon made them ill. Badauni was sent back to Fatehpur Sikri with the rana’s special elephant, Ram Prasad, to give an account of the battle to Akbar. When Badauni told the Padshah the name of the elephant, Akbar announced that, ‘since all this [success] has been brought about through the Pir, its name henceforth shall be Pir Prasad’. Akbar was considerably less pleased with Man Singh’s clear reluctance to capture or kill the rana. While the other great generals like Ghazi Khan Badakshi, Mihtar Khan, Ali Murad Uzbek, and a few others, were all summoned to court and honoured, Man Singh and Asaf Khan were not. Akbar’s irritation was fleeting, however, and Man Singh was received at court in late September 1576. However, the following year, when